

#6: Does acquiring knowledge destroy our sense of wonder? Discuss with reference to two areas of knowledge.

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Prescribed Title 6: Does acquiring knowledge destroy our sense of wonder? Discuss with reference to two areas of knowledge.

The idea of living forever is likely an idea that crosses everyone's mind when they are young. I especially considered this idea after reading *Harry Potter and the Philosopher's Stone* (Rowling), which presented the idea of an elixir that would make one immortal upon consumption. This essay explores the complications of such "magical" beliefs, specifically, does the acquisition of knowledge destroy one's sense of wonder?

To better understand this question, "Knowledge acquisition" and "wonder" should be defined. In a general sense, acquiring knowledge is an external process of discovery. Knowledge is labelled, ordered, standardized, and structured using processes such as the scientific method or peer review to maintain authenticity. This is often used to dispel myths by solving and explaining wonder in the scientific universe, but depending on the nature of the knowledge, can also lead to the reveal of wonders of the world, like in art. In contrast, the "sense of wonder" introduced in the title is commonly associated with abstract ideas such as one's imagination. It is anything that aligns with the individual's emotional fascination as they perceive the world, or anything sensorial and that has meaning to a certain person, giving "wonder" a highly individualistic and subjective nature. In this way, wonder directly contrasts the objective nature of acquiring knowledge. The prescribed question assumes that knowledge and wonder are directly related, that acquiring knowledge will either destroy or increase a sense of wonder. This is an incorrect assumption as both knowledge and wonder are complex in nature, and the relationship between them is much more complicated than that. If knowledge is created by us, in the form of

perception and explanations, would that mean wonder is also human-made? Are "wonder" and "knowledge" synonymous?

This essay will explore the question in relation to the natural sciences and the arts, two areas of knowledge that have sparked wonder in the world for ages. Though new discoveries can be made in the natural sciences, the better parts of chemistry, physics, and biology are already fixed, and people tend to believe in these old theories until they can truly prove otherwise. The natural sciences believe in rationalism: a belief that reasoning is the best way to acquire knowledge, especially on standardized topics (Markie). On the other hand, knowledge in the arts can come from experience or a spark of inspiration. This area of knowledge is stressed by empiricists, who throw away theories and believe knowledge is gained from perception and sensorial experience (Markie).

Natural Scientists have wondered about the world for the longest time, because to them, this is what gives them the largest sense of wonder. Acquiring knowledge surrounding this destroys an individual's sense of awe because the world is subject to human control. The mundane explanations and reasoning that humans have created take away from the wonder that formerly existed in the natural world. This is seen in the study of alchemy. Early alchemists such as Issac Newton and Paracelsus believed that gold, and later on the elixir of life, could be formed from base metals and natural materials. However, the declaration of gold as an element shattered this belief because elements cannot be created (at least without a sufficient particle accelerator - so alchemy is proven false). Newton wrote about a recipe for the philosopher's stone and countless alchemists have searched for it but it has never been discovered or created (Sheikh). Immortality has yet to exist on planet earth, leading philosophers and scientists to begin to treat the search for such a stone as a metaphor for personal enlightenment (Mythology Worldwide). In

early history, medicines were also seen as "magical", as they mysteriously cure sickness. In modern days, we learn that medicine only momentarily relieves and suppresses symptoms of sickness as it binds itself to molecular targets, blocking and suppressing their activity (Crowley). This explanation gives us clarity, but removes a sense of fascination with the unknown. In a sense, the sense of fascination we commonly associate with wonder comes from what we don't know, a belief that somewhere, there is a mystical force beyond human understanding. As soon as this unknown is studied, most times the mundane science behind it is revealed, shattering wonder.

Some, however, would argue that the more knowledge one has, the more sense of wonder or fascination is generated. In the sciences, gaining knowledge (the ability to explain phenomena, or tools to help do so) allows us to discover more about the things around us. For example, increased knowledge in the space exploration sector has revealed much more of what was formerly unknown to us. This is a wonder within itself, as it is surprising how much scientists had of a world they could not see. The Hubble Space Telescope, first proposed in the 1940s and launched in 1990, was able to show us the expansion of the universe, but also revealed marvels like dark matter and the origins of the cosmos which we have still yet to explain (NASA). Such discoveries also make us wonder about the possibilities that could happen in the future. Breakthroughs as such deepen our sense of awe, and each bit of knowledge gained unlocks more profound and existential questions. The more we learn, the more we wonder, and this continuous cycle carries through.

In the Arts, knowledge is much more abstract than in the natural sciences. Acquiring knowledge in the Arts can be an emotion, or experience in creating art, or even a sudden spark of inspiration. This knowledge is much more open to the general population because everyone feels

emotion. This universality increases people's sense of fascination. Acquiring knowledge in this area enables individuals to better pursue knowledge. I attended an art class for ten years, and that really allowed me to see progression in my works. Starting with cartoon drawings, to sketching, watercolor, and finally oil painting, each new stage I moved up into needed prior "knowledge" and experience from the last stage. The knowledge I gained opened up new areas within the realm of the arts, and showed me signs of wonder, enhancing creativity, another form of wonder. Walt Whitman's works are an example of how certainty enhances wonder. Through studying his works, one begins to wonder about human existence itself. Whitman was a poet from the 1800s, but his works are unique in that "unlike other mystics, [Whitman could] describe his mystical experience in specific and concrete terms" (Ash). His association with mysticism was so strong that this was reflected in his poetry, and the clarity of his writing allowed others to experience his ideas, which were quite unique, thus developing fascination for this sort of unknown (Ash). Expertise from experience gives us more ability to then explore art. It also gives us a more informed aesthetic judgement allowing one to expand the realm of arts in unexpected directions.

However, advancements in technology also defeat the sense of wonder associated with art. New tools and the implementation of how to use these tools stifles our wonder, our ability to create. The status quo of art has been disrupted so much that *Comedian*, a banana duct taped to a wall, was called art and sold at over 5 million dollars (CBC, NPR). The wonder that was once directed at the expertise and thought behind a piece now turns to the concept behind it. It leads to the question: If anything can be art, does art still inspire awe? The pure simplicity in which art like the banana was created defeats any sense of fascination for modern art according to many artists, who feel threatened by the onset of technology generated art, lacking originality. AI models like DALL-E 2, which have recently been developed to be capable of turning text to

words, can generate any image in seconds. Many have argued that AI generation will “lead to the homogenization of art styles” (AI Therapy). AI art loses the “human touch” once associated with art, that made it feel authentic and personal, but technology only makes it bland and predictable now (AI Therapy). “Artificial Intelligence” itself is a misnomer. There is no real creativity, independence, or consciousness in such a model, thus no wonder can be attributed to such technology (Mineo).

In an area of knowledge where information is universal, explanations created, and new ideas less accepted, acquiring knowledge definitely destroys one's fascination with the world. This is because our natural imaginative brains have been suppressed by the natural laws of the universe. This is demonstrated in the natural sciences. In contrast, an area of knowledge with abstract, accepting ideas, encourages and naturally fosters "wonder" without its strict guidelines. Arthur C. Clarke once wrote that “Any sufficiently advanced technology is indistinguishable from magic,” emphasizing the fact that with the evolution of modern society, “real” magic is introduced to our lives, sparking interest and awe (“Clarke’s Three Laws”). This is most prominent in an area of knowledge such as the arts. Overall, whether an increase in knowledge destroys a sense of wonder depends on the nature of the knowledge, and the subject area.

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